faith consent to choose me as their head, and to place themselves under my counsel'.[31]

In just over a week, he managed to bribe Aminullah Khan to desert the Sadozai camp. A week after that he had won over Mir Haji, and with him the Kabul 'ulema and the Kohistanis.[32] Akbar Khan also recruited and armed an infantry and artillery regiment made up of Indian sepoys who had deserted from the British during the retreat. By the end of May, 12,000 troops had rallied to his standard, outnumbering the Sadozai defenders three to one.[33] After a month of sustained bombardment and the mining, and having exhausted his stock of gunpowder and cannon balls, Fatteh Jang was finally compelled to surrender. Akbar Khan was admitted into the Bala Hisar on 7 June.

By the end of that month, Fatteh Jang had been forced to hand over all powers to Akbar, who formally appointed himself wazir, then promptly seized all the latter's assets. Fatteh Jang was made to write to Pollock and explain, 'I have given to Sirdar Mahomad Akbar Khan the full and entire management of all my property and affairs of every description and have resigned to him in perpetuity full power to judge and settle all questions on all points. Whatever arrangements he may make with the English government I agree to and confirm and no alteration shall be made.'[34]

Initially, it seems, Akbar Khan still felt the need of a Sadozai figurehead to legitimise his rule: despite the taint the dynasty had suffered by allying themselves with the hated Kafirs, such was the charisma of the lineage of Ahmad Shah Durrani that even now Akbar felt it necessary to keep a Sadozai as head of state.[35] By July, however, he had tired of the fiction, and when in the middle of the month he intercepted a letter between Fatteh Jang and Pollock, he immediately had all the Sadozai shahzadas and the old blind Shah Zaman rounded up and imprisoned at the top of the Bala Hisar. 'Akbar considered this letter to contravene all traditions of honour and to violate the Shah's pact with him,' wrote Fayz Mohammad. 'He thereupon took the Shah into custody and expropriated all the jewels and fine things which Fatteh Jang had acquired. Still not satisfied, the Wazir wanted to punish the Shah with a whipping, and confiscate everything he owned.'[36]

It was at the height of his power as wazir, with the Bala Hisar now his personal palace, that Akbar Khan decided to invite to dinner the British officers who had been captured at the fall of Ghazni, and who had recently been brought to Kabul on his orders to join the other hostages. Among their